

up the first character of the ciphertext. A few words later, the disks are rotated and the new alignment of the letters will create a totally new cipher. By doing this, the effectiveness of frequency analysis becomes limited and the cipher emerges as a strong one.

Despite other limitations, the constant rotation of these disks would change the cipher countless times, within the message. At that time, this was a pioneering concept in cryptography.

German influence

Trithemius, a German monk, gave cryptography a

major boost way back in 1518. Interestingly, his deep interest in all things occult drew him to the realm of secret communication. He authored six books on 'Polygraphia' and created a polyalphabetic cipher. It was a table consisting of repeated alphabets in each row, with a duplicate sequence above it having a letter shifted in the arrangement. The message can be coded when the first alphabet of the plaintext is substituted with the first row, the second letter from the second row and so on.

English messages

The prevalence of cryptography in old England has been traced to the philosopher Roger Bacon and the poet Geoffrey Chaucer. During the reign of Henry VII, cryptography was used by supporters of Perkin Warbeck, who was the Duke of York and the younger son of Edward IV. Warbeck was a renowned figure in the English court. However, his attempts at annexing Cornwall failed and resulted in his execution.

Amidst the entire furore, a substitution cipher for Warbeck has been documented. The prosecution record of indictment of the Earl of Warbeck



King Ferdinand VII